

Keeping Tabs

Dr Manju Singh and Dr R.P. Singh, deputy directors of AICTE, talk about the role of AICTE

How does AICTE ensure that colleges provide up-to-the-mark computer education?

The National Board of Accreditation (NBA) has started evaluating the quality of education in the AICTE-accredited institutions. The accreditation grades are three-tiered. 'A' grade signifies that the quality of the program is at par with any other country. 'B' signifies that though the institution satisfies all the norms, some weaknesses still exist which can be rectified in a short period (2-3 months). Grade C signifies that the institution may be satisfying basic norms, but a few things are lacking, which can be rectified in a few years.

What are the minimum requirements for colleges wanting to offer computer-related courses?

AICTE has specified different norms for different levels of institutions. Basically, these include a furnished building, all machinery and equipment and qualified director and faculty to student ratio of 1:15.

How does AICTE check to see whether guidelines are being followed?

AICTE monitors the college yearly for the first four-five years, or till the first two batches graduate. The college has to then get itself graded by the NBA. If the NBA reports that regulations are not being met, an inquiry committee is instituted. Based on its report, various punitive actions are taken.

never got a chance to actually practise them. It was only towards the end of the semester, 15 days prior to the exam, when we actually saw what each command did."

Rohit Sharma, a marketing executive based in Punjab, faced a similar problem. Says Rohit "During my BA (1996) First Year, as a student of one of the best colleges of Chandigarh, I had computer science as a subject. In the once-a-week practical class, of one-hour duration, four students used to share one computer, which came out to a paltry 15 minutes per student per week!"

One might say that this used to happen five years ago, which is a long time; things must have changed by now. Sure, they should have! Comments Rohit, "They have but not to the extent they should have. My brother Mohit, who's a student of the same college, tells me that now instead of four, two students share a computer. This also isn't sufficient. They should at least allocate one PC to each student."

The great divide

In complete contrast to colleges, the system at the PG level is more comprehensive and up-to-date than the one at the graduate level. Compares Aashish Sharma, an MCA degree holder from Punjab University, Chandigarh "In BCom final year, I chose Computers as an additional subject, which involved study of bare basic topics like

computer fundamentals. In contrast, MCA was a totally different experience. I had subjects like Oracle, VB, etc. What I did in BCom was a joke."

The difference between graduate and post-graduate education exists not only in terms of the curriculum, but also in terms of the infrastructure. Says Sajitha Verma, a former Novell engineer, "I did my MSc during 1988-90. Even in those days we had an excellent computer lab which had the latest equipment. Also, our syllabus used to get revised each semester."

Such differences have always existed as post-graduate level courses are given more preference. But in the case of computer education, it is important that the gap be shortened by as much as possible. This is because a student, who studied BASIC and PASCAL in college, is suddenly expected to master Oracle and Visual Basic. The student is suddenly subjected to pressures of not only understanding whatever is taught but also to score good marks in examinations that will eventually help him get a decent job.

Who's responsible?

In India, the All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE) plays a major role in planning

and co-ordinated development of the technical education system throughout the country. The syllabus and curriculum is decided by the management or the university of which the college is a part, but AICTE is the governing body which after careful inspection accredits college/university to start computer and other technical courses. Not only does it grant permission, it also helps the local institutions that are accredited to it in formulating new rules and regulations from time to time.

When a college or university sends a request to AICTE for approval, it is forwarded to the National Body for Accreditation (NBA). It was constituted by the AICTE as an Autonomous Body, under Section 10(u) of the AICTE Act, 1987. NBA conducts evaluation of technical institutions or programs on the basis of guidelines, norms and standards specified by AICTE.

Says Dr I.K. Bhatt, Advisor, AICTE, "These guidelines help to serve a purpose as they help to



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Aashish Sharma

Programmer, HCL, Delhi

maintain a uniform syllabus. They are under constant scrutiny and it helps to monitor the system effectively."

However, the problem with a centralised university structure with no autonomous colleges is that changing of syllabus to keep up with the changing trend is a long-drawn process. This can easily take up to five years, in which time the technology may have leap-frogged, so that the gap still remains. So, many a time it is left to individual colleges to circumvent the University process and introduce courses and new subjects on their own, even though the same may not have any bearing on the examinations.

Given such a state, there're very few options that a student has. An enterprising student might decide to take the initiative and probably engage himself in project work with industries even while completing the course. At the same time, keeping abreast of the latest through books and the Internet is another viable option. ■

The true identity of some of the people mentioned in this story has been withheld on request.

Learning computers in a college?

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